

streamentry - the practice of awakening

r/streamentry

JOINED

TABLE OF CONTENTS

- The /r/streamentry Beginner's Guide
  - Part One: Why Practice?
    - The Path
    - Important Warnings
  - Part Two: Basic Orientation
  - Part Three: The Three Pillars of Practice
    - Commitment
    - Self-Direction
    - Honesty
  - Part Four: Attitude Adjustment
    - Example: Attitude in Breath Meditation
  - Part Five: Exploring the Breath (Weeks 1-4)
  - Part Six: Radiating Mettā (Weeks 5-8)
  - Part Seven: Dissolving Craving (Weeks 9-12)
    - Craving and Clinging
    - The Practice
  - Part Eight: Next Steps

The /r/streamentry Beginner's Guide

many viewpoints, methods, and techniques out there, and even here on this subreddit, and making sense of all of this information can be confusing. This guide keeps things simple by sticking to the essentials, giving you a solid and well-tested plan that will get you on the right track right away, and prepare you for more advanced investigations later.

The core of this guide is a 12-week course comprising three phases of four weeks each:

- The first phase focuses on exploring and cultivating awareness of the breath to refine the sensitivity of perception and develop states of joyful and energetic calm.
- The second phase focuses on generating and radiating *mettā*, loving-kindness, both to develop states of bliss and unification, and as a means to insight into the workings of the mind.
- The third phase builds on what you learned in the first two phases and takes your awareness and practice to a higher level. You will learn about the proximate cause of suffering—*craving*—and how to detect and defuse it in the earliest stages of its emergence.

(You can adjust the durations of the phases if you want, but you should spend at least four weeks on each phase in order to develop substantial experience with the practices.)

In choosing to commit to this course, know that you're not alone! We have a very active community of practitioners at all experience levels and from a wide variety of backgrounds. If at any time you feel lost, or run into obstacles not adequately addressed in this guide or the resources to which it refers—or if you simply feel like discussing your thoughts and experiences with others—please post a question or comment in the weekly *Questions and General Discussion* thread, which can always be found near the top of the /r/streamentry main page, and mention this guide.

If you'd like one-to-one guidance with this course, see the Mentors page, which lists people who are available to provide direct personal assistance and dialogue.

Note: At time of writing, the book *The Mind Illuminated* (*TMI*) is a very popular course of practice, recommended and widely discussed here. You may wonder why we don't simply advise you to follow it. There are several reasons for this. One is that it's always good to have multiple options available; on the path, no single approach works well for everyone. Another, perhaps more important, reason is that we have found that many beginners have difficulty with *TMI* because of its dense technical and technique-oriented style and strong emphasis on stages of progress. This often leads to a missing of the forest for the trees, anxiety about levels of progress, and insufficient emphasis on the beauty, pleasure, joy, and exploratory and playful aspects of practice. Having said that, *TMI* is an extraordinary resource that has set a new standard for meditation manuals, and contains a wealth of valuable and detailed information you won't find in the same lucid form anywhere else. If you would like to base your practice on *TMI*, by all means do so, and either way make sure to find a copy of the book. If you choose to follow the course given here, then by the end of it you should be well prepared to take up *TMI* practice if you so wish, while avoiding the forementioned pitfalls.

Before starting down this path, it's important to be clear about why you're doing it.

The Path

Many people hear about meditation practice in the context of stress or anxiety relief, or as a therapeutic tool for overcoming problematic habits and increasing personal self-awareness ("mindfulness"). These are all worthy goals, and there's nothing wrong with them. But the path we're concerned with here goes far, far beyond them. Since the notion of such a path may be new to you, let's look at it a little more closely.

The path can be conceived of in different ways, but the simplest one may be this: *a way that leads to the total end of suffering*. Along the way, one also comes to an understanding of the true nature of reality and the human mind—which turn out to be very different from what we usually suppose them to be. Perhaps surprisingly then, we find that *eliminating suffering* and *seeing the truth of things* are two sides of the same coin.

The word *suffering* here is used in a slightly specialized way. We are not talking about natural reactions like physical pain, or the fear that arises in the body when you see a bus heading straight for you. Such reactions are a necessary and inseparable part of human life. By *suffering* we rather mean the wide range of *habitual patterns of ignorance and internal conflict* that afflict the human mind. These patterns range from the very gross and obvious—like getting caught up in a storm of negative reactions in response to what someone else says—to the unconscious and extremely subtle—like the deep intuitive sense that you're a separate self caught up in a dangerous and unpredictable world. These patterns are responsible for virtually all of what we experience as suffering. By seeing through the mistaken perceptions and understandings on which they're based, it is possible and even practical to reach, in this human life, the total end of suffering.

- Reflect on your own motivation for starting and committing to practice. Are you prepared to sustain this motivation even when the going gets difficult, as it surely will at times? Are you sure you want to begin to uncover how things really are, even if that conflicts with how you imagine or want them to be?

Important Warnings

The path begins at the surface of daily life and leads into the deepest recesses of one's being. It's a process of discovering, confronting, and releasing tensions in the body, barriers in the heart, and ignorance in the mind. As we move deeper, many of us will uncover pockets of powerful and difficult emotions, such as existential fear, grief, and despair. Such phases are sometimes referred to as passing through the *dark night*, but really there's nothing to be afraid of—it's a natural part of finding out and adapting to the fact that some of our most deeply held unconscious beliefs about how things are are actually wrong. As our insight continues to deepen, we move into realms of joy and freedom beyond anything we've ever experienced before.

Nevertheless, there are risks in uncovering buried and sometimes intense emotions and reactions as we walk this road. Some may experience only brief and minor periods of discomfort, but others

- The practices we will pursue in this guide are designed to minimize the impact of such difficult experiences by emphasizing the cultivation of states of pleasure, joy, and loving-kindness. Having access to such states greatly, if not entirely, mitigates the transient negative effects that sometimes arise with growing insight. If you ever feel that your practice is becoming dry, cold, or mechanical, or leading into negative emotional territory, we strongly urge you *not to stop practicing*, but to *shift your practice toward mettā* (described in Part Six below). Mettā is an extraordinarily powerful antidote to transient negative or destabilizing effects that some people experience at points along the path.
- The warning above not to stop practicing if you encounter difficult territory is very important. The most effective way to move through such territory quickly is with consistent, or even redoubled, practice. If you stop, you may remain in that territory until your practice resumes.
- Another important thing to remember if difficulties arise is that you're not alone. Communities like this one, both online and offline, are here to help. If in doubt, ask for help and advice! You can always ask questions in the weekly *Questions* thread near the top of the /r/streamentry main page. If you feel the need for one-to-one guidance, you should seek out a teacher or mentor.
- Reflect on your life circumstances. Are you physically healthy, and consistently getting enough food and rest? Are you mentally prepared to handle the possible surfacing of difficult emotions or memories as your practice deepens? If in doubt, ask in the weekly *Questions* thread for advice, or seek assistance from a qualified healthcare professional. Seeking such assistance is especially important if you have reason to believe you may be suffering from a clinical mental health problem.
- This guide focuses primarily on meditative practice, but it's important to remember that formal meditation is not the whole of the path. The ending of suffering often involves making changes in our life circumstances, such as maintaining a healthy body and mind in the ordinary sense, stopping counterproductive behavior, and taking responsibility for our life situation. Meditation practice can, however, help you do these things by increasing your sensitivity to the effects of your actions, giving you insight into how to make effective changes, and providing access to reserves of energy and profoundly healing states of joy and kindness toward yourself and others.

Part Two: Basic Orientation

When reading about the path or discussing it with others, you will run into a number of terms and concepts that experienced practitioners use to communicate about certain stages, experiences, and phenomena. You should become familiar with these so that you can understand what people are saying and communicate more effectively about your own experiences.

- Begin by reading the Frequent Questions and Answers page in full. When you can, follow some of the links and references given there to develop a fuller understanding of the topics it deals with.

meditation.

- *Extra credit:* It's helpful to have a grasp of basic Buddhist concepts and terminology, as they're often used in describing experiences, practices, and aspects of the path. For a good and relatively brief crash course in Buddhist thought, read *What the Buddha Taught* by Walpola Rahula.

Part Three: The Three Pillars of Practice

The path we're describing here depends on three foundational pillars: *commitment*, *self-direction*, and *honesty*.

Commitment

Commitment means, at the most basic level, that you're going to practice *every day*. In this respect, the path is not different from other endeavors that require extensive training, like becoming an expert musician, athlete, or doctor. In all of these fields, committed regular study and practice is essential. In some ways, the path is much easier than these other trainings: it doesn't require great bodily strength or agility, or mastery of large numbers of facts and tools. In other ways, perhaps, it's harder: it requires uncovering and facing parts of the mind that are deeply buried, something few people are willing to do. And, eventually, it requires looking into the most basic processes of human thought and perception with great subtlety and finesse.

As in other domains, though, commitment makes the difference between treading water for months or years, and really transforming the mind. There is a world of difference between a practitioner who practices a couple of days a week or sits every day for two weeks and then ignores practice for a month, and one who sits every day. This kind of commitment is not easy, and your first major challenge as a beginner is to take a hard look at your life and motivations, and find a way to sustain a strong commitment to daily practice.

A couple of tips on commitment to practice:

- It's better to practice for a short time every day than for a long time on some days and not at all on others. Even on particularly busy or difficult days, you can find at least ten minutes to practice, and doing so is very important.
- Sustaining a commitment to practice is a lot easier if you make sure that practice is enjoyable. See the next part for more about grounding your practice in pleasure and joy.

Self-Direction

The second foundational pillar is *self-direction*, which means taking responsibility for your own practice and study. This path does not require that you *believe* anything. Instead, your role is that of scientist conducting a fascinating experiment that could completely change the world. You will, of course, rely on ideas and instructions from others who have preceded you—but only long enough to test them in the laboratory of your own direct experience. Your overall attitude and approach should

A simple formula that summarizes this attitude is *make your practice your own*. Practitioners who slavishly follow the instructions of others—however good those instructions may be—are very likely to get stuck for long periods of time without noticing it. Practitioners who, on the other hand, *take full responsibility* for their practice and progress, and consistently look for ways to live and practice more effectively in their particular circumstances, invariably fly the farthest. The path is mastered, not through obedience, but through self-reliance, ingenuity in the face of obstacles, and ruthless self-honesty.

It's not always easy to find a balance between relying on your own instincts and innate intelligence, and following the instructions of others. If you're following someone else's instructions, and they don't seem to be working, should you just keep doing what you're doing, try making some personal tweaks, or give up and do something different? If you persist, maybe you'll waste a lot of time going nowhere. But if you stop and do something else, maybe you'll never push through the key barrier you need to cross to make progress. Practitioners are often warned not to scatter themselves too thinly across different teachings and techniques, lest they become like the oilman who dug 20 shallow wells in different places instead of one deep one leading to the oil.

There's no simple answer to this question, but in the end it's up to you to make the call. Fortunately, this gets easier as you progress, because you'll start to develop an intuition for when you're on the right track. Also, a good practice method that fits you well will usually bring immediate results, reducing the depth and "stickiness" of suffering and increasing your sense of freedom in this very moment. This feedback helps you determine whether you're going in the right direction.

Finally, you don't have to walk this path alone. Finding community with others traveling the same road, in person or online, is deeply rewarding and can be of great help when you encounter difficult or confusing territory. You can also seek out a teacher, again either in your area or online, if you feel the need for more direct personal instruction.

Honesty

The third pillar is *honesty*, and we already hinted at its importance above. As humans, most of us grow up experts in unwitting self-delusion; in hiding parts of ourselves away from scrutiny and shielding our fragile egos in layers of avoidance and comforting lies.

Setting out on the path means acknowledging this state of affairs, seeing clearly that it leads nowhere, and resolving to counter the habitual tendency toward self-delusion with penetrating and unremitting self-honesty. Such honesty leads to clarity about what needs to be done, to profound humility, and to a deep and genuine sense of humor about ourselves as humans and the often crazy lives we lead. These developments in turn transform our relationship to life, and guide our practice into vast new territories we never could have imagined.

Part Four: Attitude Adjustment

to neglect the importance of attitude, and to attempt to force progress with effort and strain. This doesn't work, and leads only to frustration and burnout.

In order for practice to become a self-sustaining activity and yield real fruit, it's essential for it to be enjoyable, fascinating, and fun. That's not to say that every one of your sessions will be pleasant—some, on the contrary, will be downright harrowing. But *in general*, your practice should be grounded in a sense of relaxation, alertness, joy, pleasure, curiosity, and gentleness toward yourself. These are the qualities that provide a sound and sustainable foundation for the attainment of deep states of absorption, profound insight, and ultimate release.

Of course, finding ways to ground your practice in joy, pleasure, curiosity, and gentleness also takes practice! You'll have to play and experiment to find ways to evoke, nurture, and cultivate these qualities. In doing so you'll avoid the biggest beginner mistake, and save yourself months, if not years, of unnecessary frustration.

Example: Attitude in Breath Meditation

For a simple example of right versus wrong attitude, consider the basic instruction to *sit and focus attention on sensations of the breath at the nostrils*. If you've ever tried to do this, you may have found it quite difficult to maintain awareness of the breath this way for even a few seconds, let alone for ten minutes, thirty minutes, or an hour! The mind continually gets caught up in distractions, and attention jumps to thoughts, fantasies, memories, and stories instead of remaining on the breath.

The wrong-attitude approach is to deal with this obstacle by using effort to try to force the attention to stay on the breath. This is usually what a beginner will do when they encounter the obstacle of mind-wandering. It's natural, because we're used to overcoming obstacles through effort in other parts of life. We may not even know there's any other possibility! But although this kind of effort and forcing may lead to temporary states of concentration, it's a dead end—it will never lead to real progress, because it's only another instance of the mind fighting itself. Trying to force attention to stay on an object this way will produce feelings of tightness, tension, frustration, and being off balance.

The right-attitude approach, on the other hand, is to begin by taking a few big, deep breaths and *really enjoying them*. We spend the first five, ten, or thirty minutes of a session just relaxing deeply, sinking into the many deep and interesting sensations of the body and breath, tuning in especially to the pleasure, joy, and relaxation that can readily be found just beneath the surface of our everyday anxious and restless life. After sinking deeply into the body and this profound and pleasurable sense of relaxation—while remaining present and alert!—we *very gently* begin tuning in to the sensations of the breath as it moves slowly in and out. Gently we tune in more and more to these sensations—while remaining grounded in a relaxed, full awareness of the whole body—and find that they're beautifully elaborate and complex. The more we tune in, the deeper we can explore this mysterious intricacy of the breath. We find whole worlds in these sensations that we never knew existed, because we always assumed they were nothing special, and never bothered to look.

attention from it completely—and then taking a deep breath and *re-relaxing the whole body*. Distractions bring tension along with them, so to fully release the distraction, remembering to fully relax the body this way is important. After releasing the distraction and any tension that may have arisen, we gently return to a relaxed and pleasurable awareness of the whole body, and tune in again to the sensations of the breath.

Practicing consistently in this way, we find that, over time, the attention will simply remain on the breath for longer and longer periods. This happens, not because we're forcing it to stay there, but because more and more energy is being withdrawn from distractions. When distractions subside this way, the attention remains on the breath by itself, without any effort on our part. This is how real states of concentration, unification of mind, and meditative absorption arise.

Part Five: Exploring the Breath (Weeks 1-4)

Now that you have some background, and have sincerely reflected on the importance of commitment, self-direction, honesty, and attitude toward practice, it's time to begin a formal sitting practice.

For the first four weeks, the focus of your practice will be the breath. As hinted at above, the breath is enormously—infinitely, really—rich and complex, and the potential source of healing energies and pleasures beyond anything you've experienced before. We ordinarily think of the breath as nothing special, just air moving in and out of the lungs. But this ordinary view is simply incorrect, arising from lack of attention and failure to explore this most essential process of human life. During these four weeks, your task is to become as sensitive as you can to the breath and the depths and intricacies of bodily sensation it connects with, and thereby to get a taste for yourself of the pleasures and possibilities it holds.

- First, decide on a daily practice schedule. It's best to practice at the same time every day if possible: the regularity of the pattern will support the mind in calming, and make it easier to sit consistently. Choose a time when you'll be wakeful and alert, and a place where you'll be comfortable and free of external distractions.
- Ideally, you should practice twice a day, once in the morning and once in the evening. An excellent starting schedule is to sit for 30 minutes twice a day. If this seems too much to start, then 20 minutes is fine. Even for experienced practitioners it often takes the mind about 15-20 minutes to settle down, so the longer you can sit beyond this point, the more effective your sessions are likely to be.
- Aim to increase the duration of each sit gradually over time, e.g. by adding 5-10 minutes each week. If you can work up to practicing for 60 minutes twice a day consistently, you'll have a very robust foundation for rapid progress. Even 45 minutes twice a day is excellent. It's important, though, not to force yourself to sit for longer than you can reasonably manage. Always be gentle toward yourself, and allow your practice to grow organically. If your circumstances only allow you to sit for 20 minutes a day for now, that's just fine—especially if you really treasure those 20 minutes.

book contains the main practice instructions for this phase of your practice. The chapter is not very long, but it contains a lot of information—you'll want to refer back to it often as your exploration of the breath deepens. You should also become familiar with Part Two of the book, which lists common problems you may run into—such as drowsiness, wandering thoughts, and physical discomfort—and tactics for resolving them.

- Over the course of these four weeks, also listen to the following audio talks, which contain practice instructions and guided meditations that are fully compatible with the method described in *With Each and Every Breath*. (You may even wish to begin here before reading Part One of the book.) These talks are enormously helpful in conveying the sense of what breath meditation is about, and reinforcing the attitudes of gentleness, play, and exploration that are so essential for the practice to flower:
  - First Instructions on Breath Meditation
  - Second Instructions on Breath Meditation
  - Third Instructions on Breath Meditation
  - Fourth Instructions on Breath Meditation
- During this time, you should also begin to practice *off the cushion*—in daily life, outside of your formal sitting time. The more you can find ways to extend your practice off the cushion this way, the faster you'll progress and start seeing results that begin to transform your life. There are many ways to practice in daily life. Perhaps the most fundamental is to begin to *observe the state of the body and the movements of the mind at all times*. This conscious background awareness of the body/mind must eventually become continuous, and provides the foundation for truly transformative insight, as the mind begins to understand its own workings and, in consequence, generate less suffering. You can take this practice a step further, as follows:
- Maintain a continuous awareness of the whole body, and be alert for any sense of *tension or contraction* that may develop. This will happen in response to various external circumstances. You will also find that when the mind wanders and gets lost in thought, this distraction will be accompanied and supported by such tension or contraction somewhere in the body. When you detect either mind-wandering or bodily tension, respond by *releasing* the thought the mind is fixating on; *relaxing* the whole body and breathing through any areas of tension; and *returning* the mind to the present moment and the breath. This is an extremely powerful and effective form of practice that can be done at all times, that brings immediate relief and freedom in the moment, and that can lead to deep insight into how the mind habitually fabricates delusion and suffering. For more about practice in daily life, you can read Part Three of *With Each and Every Breath*.
- One of the more common and insidious obstacles encountered in breath practice is *dullness* (also called *sinking* or *torpor*). Unlike an agitated mind, which is relatively easy to notice, the beginner may fail to notice that the mind has begun to sink into dullness—or even mistake it for a sign of progress! This is because states of dullness are often pleasant and, by nature, relaxing—indeed, they tend to lead to dreamlike, disconnected thoughts and eventually to falling asleep! Dull states are, however, dead ends, so it's important to be on the lookout for dullness, as it can easily creep in undetected. To counter this, always remember that in this practice we seek to cultivate a mind that's both relaxed and *energized*—that is, bright and alert.

Dullness and its remedies are discussed in Part Two of *With Each and Every Breath* under *Drowsiness* and *Delusion Concentration*, and in the Third Instructions talk above.

- This phase of your practice is about becoming familiar with the deep and intricate territory of the breath and inner body, and learning to find pleasure, ease, and calm by allowing the mind to stabilize within the breath. The more you practice in this way, the more these qualities will expand, until the breath fills the body and mind with brightness, calm, and joy. You discover that you have, in the breath, a vast resource of these positive qualities available to you, a resource that's always present just below the surface of daily life. This in turn gives you a place of internal stability and balance—you begin to realize that the qualities your heart most longs for are right there within the body, that there's no need to search for them anywhere else.
- In addition to providing access to this ever-deepening reservoir of inner calm and energy, this practice leads to a bright and quiet mind that is ideally suited to begin to investigate and understand its own processes and movements. Such *insight investigation* is a more advanced phase of practice, and is what leads to true freedom and the cessation of suffering. You can learn more about insight investigation in Part Four of *With Each and Every Breath*, or by consulting the resources given in the *Next Steps* section below.

Part Six: Radiating Mettā (Weeks 5-8)

In the next part of your practice, you will be focusing on generating and radiating mettā. *Mettā* means *loving-kindness, friendliness, goodwill, benevolence, and concord*. It can also be understood as *a strong wish for the welfare and happiness of others or oneself*.

The practice of mettā has so many benefits that it's impossible to list them all. Fundamentally, mettā is a rapid path to powerful unification of mind, as well as a bridge connecting our inner practice with the outer world. It's also one of the quickest and most potent ways to generate blissful energetic states that fill the body and mind, states that can lead to profound healing and serve as a deep well that can be drawn upon during difficult times in practice or life. Furthermore, the mettā practice you will be doing in this phase also incorporates *insight investigation*, the direct path to a full understanding of the processes of mind and to the end of suffering.

- Your practice schedule should continue as usual, but now your sits should each be at least 30 minutes.
- Now that you've grown somewhat familiar with calming the mind via the breath, it will be very helpful to begin your practice sessions in this phase with at least a few (5-15) minutes of breath focus in order to settle and energize the mind.
- Here are the practice instructions for this phase. You may also wish to read the original instruction booklet mentioned in the first paragraph there.
- During this phase, also listen to the following audio talks. As with the breath practice, these are of great help in getting a genuine feel for mettā practice. The last three talks extend beyond the main practice instructions given above. You can either explore them if you have extra time to practice during this phase, or save them for later.
    - About Metta Practice

- Metta Instructions and Guided Meditation 3
- Metta Instructions and Guided Meditation 4
- Metta Instructions and Guided Meditation 5

- As will be clear if you've listened to the talks, mettā practice is highly complementary to breath practice. These two kinds of practice reinforce one another, invigorating and unifying the mind and the body's energy system. Mettā adds a dimension of the heart to practice that can quickly bear extraordinary fruit.
- In the last phase you learned about practicing in daily life by observing the state of the body and the movements of the mind, and by watching for any sense of tension or contraction in the body/mind system. The *release, relax, return* method you learned for handling tension and distraction is precisely the 6R method described in the practice instructions for this phase. Thus, you can continue to use this method as your primary practice off the cushion. Now, however, you can also add the radiation of mettā—the sincere intention of loving-kindness—to your off-cushion practice. As you go about daily life, you can summon the mettā intention and radiate it toward yourself, to those you encounter in the world, or simply to all beings. If you are able to consistently *observe the mind and body*, *detect and release mind-wandering, tension, and contraction*, and *radiate mettā* in daily life, you will have left your beginner status far behind. You now have the tools to do all these things and more—all that remains is to practice.

Part Seven: Dissolving Craving (Weeks 9-12)

In this last phase, you will use your familiarity with the breath and mettā practices as a base from which to *detect and dissolve craving and clinging*.

Craving and Clinging

Craving and clinging are the proximate causes of suffering and internal conflict in the mind. *Craving* is the movement of the mind that either seeks a (sensory or imaginary) object or experience perceived as desirable, or rejects an object or experience perceived as undesirable. The first kind is called *grasping* or *sense desire*. The second is called *aversion*.

We experience grasping and aversion as the basic forces of pull and push in the mind. When we experience or imagine something desirable we want more of it, so the mind moves toward it or tries to pull it closer. And when we encounter an undesirable experience, the mind retreats from it or tries to push it away.

Clinging is just a continuation of the motion that began as craving. When a pleasant or unpleasant experience first arises, the mind begins by reacting with grasping or aversion. This craving sets up an *attachment process* in which the experience grows larger and more prominent because of the reaction to it. This in turn fuels more craving, and so on. It's as if the mind fixates on the object, building it up and trying to hold on to it or keep it away. This fixation is what's called clinging.

constantly unfolding in the mind from moment to moment. Objects—mostly mind-generated fantasies combined with body feelings—are constantly arising in our experience, and the mind automatically reacts by trying to latch on to them or get rid of them. We can also think of craving as *resistance*: the mind is resisting the current state of not having (or having enough of) the desired experience, or the current state of having an experience it dislikes.

This is important because *craving is the crucial point of leverage in the process of suffering*. In practice we can directly short-circuit this process by detecting craving and responding to it in the right way.

Actually, you have been learning to do this from the beginning of this course. In both the breath and mettā practices, you used the *release, relax, return* method to recover skillfully from distractions. In this phase, a refinement of this method will become the main focus of your practice.

The Practice

The basic idea of the practice for this phase is to establish the mind in a state of calm and clarity using the breath or mettā practices as you've already learned, and then become more sensitive to the arising of craving. This can be done by watching carefully for the appearance of the slight tensions in the body/mind that are the precursors to distraction. When you detect that such tension is forming, recognize it, welcome it, and release and relax into it in one fluid step.

In Part Two of *With Each and Every Breath*, under *Wandering Thoughts*, the author describes it this way:

> As you get more sensitive to the subtle breath energies in the body, you'll come to notice that the act of holding onto a thought requires that you develop a slight pattern of tension somewhere in the body, as a kind of marker. Try to locate that pattern of tension, dissolve it with a breath, and the thought will go away from lack of support.
>
> As your concentration gets better, you'll be able to sense these patterns of tension forming even before they become conscious thoughts. You'll come to see the stages by which thought-worlds form. They start as little knots of tension, and then a perception is applied to them, deciding whether to view the knots as physical or as mental phenomena. If the decision is to regard them as mental, then a further perception is applied: What is this thought about?
>
> When you can see these steps, the mind in concentration becomes like a spider on a web: You stay at your spot, and then the sensitivity of the breath-web tells you that a knot of tension is forming at a particular section of the web. You go there, zap the knot with a shot of good breath energy that dissolves it, and then return to your spot.

Here are the practice instructions for this phase:

- Your sessions should now be at least 45 minutes each, if possible.
- Begin by establishing the mind in a state of joy, calm, and clarity using either the breath or the mettā practices you've already learned, or a combination of both. For example, you might start

- When the mind is calm and relatively steady, allow it to remain settled on the meditation object (the breath or the mettā intention), but open your awareness to fill the space of the whole body/mind, and begin to become aware of any subtle patterns of tension that start to form anywhere in this space. Watch especially the areas of the head (including the eyes, face, and jaw), the shoulders, the middle of the chest, and the lower abdomen. Your main objective is to increase the power and sensitivity of your awareness; to become aware of ever more subtle layers of persistent tension, and to detect the arising of tension and contraction of awareness at earlier and earlier stages.
- When you detect that a contraction in the space of awareness has begun to occur, or that a spot of tension somewhere in the body/mind has begun to form, simply welcome it, release it, and relax into it, without leaving your meditation object. When you do this, releasing and relaxing tension and allowing awareness to expand to fill the whole space of the body again, you will feel a sense of immediate freedom, relief, and joy. This sense may be very subtle or, at times, quite intense.
- As always, keep the practice light and enjoyable, and don't go looking for trouble: allow the mind to rest and remain stable on the meditation object. You can think of it as a kind of game: watching for the little knots to form and then zapping them before they grow and lead to distractions.
- Watch this whole process as you practice, and learn about how the mind works. See if you can detect craving and the subtle tensions that go with it at earlier and earlier stages, when it's still a tiny seed. Practicing in this way will yield deep and transformative insights into mind and the origins of suffering.

The main difference between this practice and the *release, relax, return* method you've already learned to use in the previous phases is that, earlier, you used this method only to recover from a distraction that had already arisen and pulled the mind away from its meditation object. Here you're working at a deeper and more advanced level that involves greater power of awareness: you're detecting the emergence of subtle tendencies in the mind, and releasing them before they have a chance to become distractions.

As before, you will find that this practice also carries over naturally into daily life off the cushion. As your awareness of the formation of craving, thought, and subtle tension increases, you find that you can detect and release it quickly and smoothly in any situation in life, before it turns into a problem. And as you watch all this happen, growing insight will emerge into the whole process of mind and how it constructs your reality. This insight in turn will reprogram the mind, and open the door to even deeper levels of practice.

This is also a good time to begin to devote a portion of your time to study, as well as practice. Study helps direct and prepare the ground of the mind for the insights that arise through practice, and provides you with a coherent framework for understanding the changes that take place as you walk the path, and where they lead. If you haven't already, finish reading the books and listening to the talks mentioned earlier in this guide.

It's said that there are two wings that bear the practitioner to Awakening and the end of suffering. The first is the cultivation of sublime states and qualities; of joy, loving-kindness, and a bright and unified mind. The second is the application of this joyful, energized, and unified mind to the penetrating investigation of self and phenomena, and the way in which both these poles of our existence are fabricated by the mind. Without the first wing, the mind is too weak and fragmented to investigate the fabrication of reality effectively. And without the second, the mind becomes complacent, never seeing deeply enough to strike its most fundamental bonds and discover the pinnacle of freedom.

During these twelve weeks, if you've practiced consistently according to this guide, you will have developed the first wing to a substantial degree. Calming and energizing the mind through the breath and through mettā leads directly to the sublime qualities just mentioned, and provides immediate relief from a great deal of mind-manufactured suffering, as well as access to realms of pleasure and clarity you never thought possible. This dimension of practice can grow significantly deeper in time.

You've also begun to develop the second wing, insight into the fabricating processes of the mind. The more you *observe* the state of the body and the workings of the mind, and apply the *release, relax, return* method to undercut mind-wandering, bodily tension, reactivity, and the suffering and anxiety caused by craving, the more you will come to understand in your own experience how all these factors relate, and how suffering is fabricated by the mind from moment to moment.

In keeping with these two wings, the task before you is twofold. First, continue to cultivate the sublime qualities and an energized and unified mind. You don't need any new techniques for this; only continue to consistently practice what you've learned in this course, and these simple methods will lead to ever more profound states of *śamatha*—bliss, stillness, and clarity—as you explore them for yourself. Second, continue to observe at all times the workings of the mind, and undertake further study and practice of insight investigation.

A good next step in your exploration of insight is this course on emptiness and dependent origination. You can begin to incorporate the methods there into your own practice as soon as you can consistently reach states of calm, clarity, and joy in your sits. The methods and exposition there are based in turn on the book *Seeing That Frees* by Rob Burbea, and the corresponding talks from the 2010 *Meditation on Emptiness* retreat at Gaia House. You should explore these resources as soon as you feel ready.

This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License.

Last revised by mirrorvoid - 3 years ago